

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Joel 1:1

The word of the Lord gave this message (literally *The word of the Lord came*): The Lord, not the human prophet, was the ultimate source of these words. • The name Joel means “the Lord [Yahweh] is God.” Joel’s father, Pethuel, is unknown apart from this verse.

Joel 1:1–2.17

Joel describes the devastating locust plague that afflicted Judah and Jerusalem.

Joel 1:2

Hear this: Joel summoned the inhabitants of the land to pay close attention to the prophetic word. • Leaders (literally *elders*): The prophet asked the community elders, has anything like this happened before? It hadn’t—this disaster was unique in the history of God’s people.

Joel 1:3

God’s people would tell future generations about what was taking place so that their descendants would benefit from the lessons they had learned (cp. [Deut 4:9](#); [6:20–25](#)).

Joel 1:4

The disaster that had befallen Judah was a catastrophic plague of locusts. Some commentators have understood the four kinds of *locusts* mentioned here to represent four ancient empires that conquered Israel. Others have suggested that the words indicate four stages in the development of locusts. Most likely, the prophet was using multiple terms to emphasize the extent of the destruction wrought by wave after wave of the voracious insects.

Joel 1:5

Wake up . . . Wail: The prophet sought to arouse the people and alert them to the gravity of the locust plague.

Joel 1:7

The destructive power of locusts is well documented in both ancient and modern times. The insatiable insects consume annual crops such as grains and vegetables, and they destroy perennial fruit-bearing trees and vines, leaving the branches white and bare.

Joel 1:8

Weep like a bride (literally *a virgin*): Judah is compared to a young betrothed woman whose marriage is never consummated due to the death of her husband.

Joel 1:9

The locust plague threatened the people of Judah with starvation and brought the regular daily animal sacrifices and offerings of grain and wine at the Temple in Jerusalem to a halt (cp. [Exod 29:38–41](#); [Num 28:2–8](#)).

Joel 1:10

The locusts destroyed the three essential staple crops of ancient Israel: grain ... grapes and olive oil.

Joel 1:12

Drought had intensified the devastation of the locust plague; everything had withered and dried up (see also [1:19–20](#)). Spiritually, the people’s joy had dried up along with the fruit trees.

Joel 1:13-14

The priests were to lead all the people in public rites of mourning at the Temple. Their outward actions must be matched by authentic inward change (see [2:13](#)).

Joel 1:15

The locust plague was not simply a natural event, but a sign that the day of the Lord was near. Beginning with Amos in the 700s BC ([Amos 5:18](#)), the prophets had spoken of a future time when God would intervene in human history to judge the wicked and vindicate the righteous. • destruction . . . from the Almighty: The Hebrew text highlights the similar sounds of the word *destruction* (shod) and the title *the Almighty* (shadday).

Joel 1:17

Plague and drought had so reduced the food supply that the barns stood empty.

Joel 1:18

The inhabitants of Judah were hard pressed by the famine; even sheep and goats, animals that can live on very meager forage, bleat in misery for lack of food.

Joel 1:19

Lord, help us! (literally *to you, Lord, I cry*): Joel responded to the plague with an earnest prayer. The people's only recourse was to turn to the sovereign Lord of heaven and earth and appeal to his goodness; he alone could reverse their desperate situation.

Joel 1:20

All creation suffers because of human sin ([Gen 3:17-18](#); [9:2](#); [Rom 8:20-21](#))—even the wild animals cry out to God. The Hebrew word translated “cry out” is the same word used in [Ps 42:1](#) of the deer that “longs” for streams of water. The beasts, urgently requiring their food and drink,

set an example of how the people of Judah and Jerusalem should seek their Lord (cp. [Isa 1:3](#)).

Joel 2:1

When an ancient city was attacked, the watchmen on the city wall would raise the alarm by blowing the trumpet, a ram's horn instrument called a shofar (see also [2:15](#)), to call all the defenders to repel the enemy.

Joel 2:1-11

Some regard this section as a second account of the locust plague described in ch [1](#), but in ch [1](#), the plague is in the past, whereas in this section, the verb tenses seem to depict it as a future event. Thus, others see it as a warning of yet another locust plague. Still other commentators have understood this passage as an apocalyptic description of the coming day of the Lord, using the language of a locust plague to describe an invading human army.

Joel 2:2

Some religious leaders had taught the people of Jerusalem and Judah that the day of the Lord would be a time of blessing for God's people. Echoing the prophet Zephaniah ([Zeph 1:15](#)), Joel proclaimed that it would instead be a day of darkness and gloom (see also [Amos 5:18-20](#)).

Joel 2:3

The destruction wrought by the invading army would be like a raging wildfire. Before the attack, the land looked like the Garden of Eden, but afterwards, it would be nothing but desolation (a reversal of [Isa 51:3](#) and [Ezek 36:35](#)).

Joel 2:4-5

They look like horses: The resemblance between locusts and horses (see also [Rev 9:7](#)) heightens the image of the locusts as an army. • Listen to the noise they make: The noise made by a locust swarm can be deafening.

Joel 2:6

Fear grips all the people: Anticipating the invasion prepared the people for the call to repentance in [2:12-14](#).

Joel 2:7-9

The locusts would invade urban as well as agricultural areas, advancing like a disciplined, well-trained army to scale city walls and swarm over the city. Finding every means of entrance, they would even climb like thieves through the windows.

Joel 2:10

The quaking of the earth and the heavens is a typical sign of *theophany*, an appearance of God (see [Exod 19:16-19](#); [Isa 13:13](#); [Nah 1:5-6](#)). The darkening of the sun and moon symbolizes divine judgment ([Isa 13:9-11](#)).

Joel 2:11

The Lord is at the head of the column (literally *the Lord utters his voice before his army*): The coming destruction was not simply an act of nature or the result of human activity, but an act of God. • This is his mighty army: God executed this judgment. • Who can possibly survive? Apart from God's grace and mercy, no one can.

Joel 2:12

This verse begins with the words the Lord says, a phrase that frequently accompanies divine speeches in the prophets. This is the only time that it occurs in Joel ("says the Lord" in [3:1](#) is supplied by the translators), and it indicates that this gracious invitation came directly from God. • Turn to me now, while there is time: The Lord implored his people to repent because the day of judgment was near. There was still opportunity to avoid the coming destruction if they returned to the Lord their God with true repentance. • Unlike other prophets, Joel never catalogs the sins committed by the people of Judah and Jerusalem. Perhaps they

were so obvious that he did not feel the need to list them.

Joel 2:12-17

Joel calls on the people to repent and throw themselves on the mercy of their compassionate God.

Joel 2:13

One means of showing grief in the ancient world was to tear one's clothing ([Gen 37:34](#); [2 Sam 3:31](#); [2 Kgs 19:1](#)). • tear your hearts: In Hebrew, the heart is the center of thought, faith, and will. God's people were to go beyond external demonstrations of repentance to repent inwardly—to change their orientation, priorities, and attitudes. This could only happen if they would return to the Lord. • for he is merciful and compassionate . . . and filled with unfailing love: The people's only hope was in the merciful character of the Lord (see also [Exod 34:6-7](#); [Num 14:18](#); [Neh 9:17](#); [Pss 86:15](#); [103:8](#); [145:8](#); [Jon 4:2](#)). God's desire is not to punish, but to forgive and restore his people.

Joel 2:14

Who knows? Joel's simple question acknowledges God's absolute sovereignty (see also [Jon 3:9](#)). God is not obligated to restore us merely because we perform certain rituals. Forgiveness comes only through divine grace, but Joel knew that God was inclined to forgive ([Joel 2:13](#)).

Joel 2:15

Joel called for a time of fasting and a solemn meeting for the purpose of seeking God.

Joel 2:16

bridegroom . . . and the bride: Newlyweds were exempt from most civic duties in ancient Israel ([Deut 24:5](#); [Luke 14:20](#)), but in this emergency, everyone would be summoned to the Temple to cry out to God.

Joel 2:17

Spare your people, Lord! Assembled at the Temple, the religious leaders and all the people were to do the only thing possible in their desperate situation: seek the mercy and compassion of God.

Joel 2:18

Since both people and land suffered from God's judgment, both would be the objects of his zealous compassion.

Joel 2:18–27

God promised to restore his people's material lives in the immediate future, replenishing their fields, orchards, vineyards, and flocks.

Joel 2:18–3:21

Up to this point, the book of Joel has focused on God's judgment upon Judah and Jerusalem, but from here on, it describes God's promise of restoration. If the people sincerely repented, God would respond graciously.

Joel 2:19–20

grain and new wine and olive oil: God would restore the fruits of the land. This would again make available the elements necessary for sacrifice and worship (see [1:10](#), [13](#)). God would also eradicate the invading armies from the north.

Joel 2:21–22

Don't be afraid: God's great deliverance would be full and complete.

Joel 2:23

autumn rains . . . rains of spring: God would once again restore the regular pattern of rainfall, and the drought ([1:12](#), [20](#)) would be reversed.

Joel 2:25

The Lord promised restitution for the terrible damage done by the locusts (see [1:4](#), [10](#), and corresponding study notes).

Joel 2:26–27

and you will praise the Lord your God: God's promised restoration of their crops and food supply should lead the people of Judah and Jerusalem to praise and adoration, acknowledging that the Lord was in their midst and that he alone is God.

Joel 2:28–29

I will pour out my Spirit upon all people: In Israel, the empowering gift of God's Spirit had previously been given only to select individuals such as judges ([Judg 3:10](#); [15:14](#)), priests ([2 Chr 24:20](#)), kings ([1 Sam 10:10](#)), and prophets ([Isa 61:1](#)). A time was coming when the Spirit would be given to every one of God's people, regardless of gender, age, or social position. In fulfillment of Moses' wish that every Israelite might be a prophet ([Num 11:29](#)), all would prophesy and see visions. In [Acts 2:1–47](#), Peter expanded this promise to include people from all over the known world who were gathered in Jerusalem, regardless of their ethnicity ([Acts 2:39](#); see also [Gal 3:28](#)).

Joel 2:28–32

The prophet looked beyond his time to the future day of the Lord, when God would pour out his Spirit in ways never before seen and would perform signs and wonders for all humanity to see. The apostle Peter quoted this passage as being fulfilled on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:16–21](#)).

Joel 2:28–3:21

In the more distant future, God would restore his people's spiritual lives, pour out his Spirit on all people who respond to him in faith, and render judgment on the peoples and nations that refuse to acknowledge his lordship.

Joel 2:30–31

The future outpouring of God's Spirit would be accompanied by signs and wonders. Blood and fire and . . . smoke, together with the darkening of the sun and the moon, are indications of God's coming in judgment (see [2:10](#); [Mark 13:24](#); [Rev 6:12](#)).

Joel 2:32

everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved: Calling on the name of God should not be a final act of desperation; it accompanies a lifelong commitment of worship, service, and fellowship with the Lord (see [Gen 12:8](#); [Ps 105:1](#); [Isa 12:4](#); [Rom 10:13](#); [12:1–2](#)). • Those whom the Lord has called are his chosen remnant, the survivors of judgment who worship him (see [2 Kgs 19:31](#); [Ezra 9:8–15](#); [Isa 10:20–22](#)).

Joel 3:1–16

Joel here foretold divine judgment on the nations, particularly those that had oppressed God's people.

Joel 3:2–3

The Lord would assemble the armies of the world (literally *all the nations*) in the valley of Jehoshaphat. This valley was not connected with King Jehoshaphat of Judah ([1 Kgs 22:41](#)); rather, this description, which means “the valley where the Lord judges,” identifies the site as the place where God would render his decision (see [Joel 3:14](#)) regarding the fate of the nations. • The sins of the nations include exiling God's covenant people and victimizing helpless boys and girls in an inhuman slave trade (cp. [Ezek 27:13](#); [Rev 18:13](#)).

Joel 3:4–6

The Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon and the cities of Philistia were guilty of looting the precious treasures of Jerusalem and selling its people as slaves to the Greeks (see [Amos 1:6, 9](#)).

Joel 3:7–8

The people of Tyre, Sidon, and Philistia had enslaved Israelites, so the Lord would punish them by selling their sons and daughters into slavery.

Joel 3:9

The nations are mockingly called to a futile war against the Lord that would end in their destruction and judgment.

Joel 3:10

Hammer your plowshares into swords: Deliberately reversing an image from [Isa 2:4](#) and [Mic 4:3](#), Joel ordered the nations to mobilize every resource for the forthcoming battle. Even those unfit for war, the weaklings, must become soldiers.

Joel 3:12

The battle would take place in the valley of Jehoshaphat (see study note on 3:2–3), where the Lord would pronounce judgment on them all.

Joel 3:13

God would defeat the nations like a sickle that mows down stalks of grain and like workers who tread grapes in the winepress (see [Isa 63:2–3](#); [Rev 14:14–20](#)).

Joel 3:14

Thousands upon thousands (literally *roaring, roaring*; or *crowds, crowds*): The repetition of the Hebrew word captures the chaotic noise made by an immense crowd. • valley of decision: The name of the valley is changed (cp. [3:2–3, 12](#)) because now the Lord's judgment had been decided.

Joel 3:16

The Lord's voice, like that of a lion, would roar from Zion, shaking heaven and earth and terrifying sinners (see [Amos 1:2](#)). Yet this same ferocious lion is also a refuge for his people.

Joel 3:17

Then you will know: God's ultimate purpose is that his people should know him and share his holy character. They must learn that he alone is God and that he reigns over all creation from Zion, his holy mountain (see also [2:27](#)). The only true security in the present, and the only hope for the future, comes from God's presence.

Joel 3:18

Blessings would flow from the Lord's sovereign presence in Zion (see also [Ezek 47:1–12](#); [Amos 9:13](#)). There would be a superabundance of sweet wine and milk. The Temple, God's own dwelling on earth, would be the source of a spring that would forever water the arid landscape (see [Zech 14:8](#); [Rev 22:1–2](#)).

Joel 3:19

Even as Judah is restored, her ancient enemies Egypt and Edom would experience God's judgment for their crimes against his people.

Joel 3:20–21

The conclusion of Joel's prophecy is the antithesis of its beginning. In [1:1–20](#), Judah's future seemed in grave doubt. Plague and drought, the signs of divine judgment, threatened Judah's existence. Now Joel ends with the divine assurance that Judah . . . and Jerusalem will endure through all generations. God's people in every generation rest secure in the hope that his kingdom will reign over heaven and earth (see also [Isa 9:6–7](#); [Dan 2:44; 7:13–14](#)).